In Their Own Words

Secession, Fort Sumter, and the Picnic at Bull Run

15 MINUTE HISTORY · NARRATION SCRIPT · 1,589 WORDS · ABOUT 9:45

> ***Driving question:*** *Why did eleven states leave the Union in 1860 and 1861? And when they did, why did almost everyone think the war would be over by summer?*

Underlined = vocabulary card on screen · *italic* = spoken with emphasis · timestamps are estimates until the voice is recorded

0:00 Cold Open

The vice president of the Confederacy once explained, in plain words, why his new country existed. After the war, he told a different story.

His name was Alexander Stephens. In March 1861, in Savannah, Georgia, he said the new government had a **cornerstone**, the stone everything else rests on. That cornerstone, he said, was slavery.

Seven years later, with the war lost, Stephens published a two-volume history of it. In that version, slavery was just the spark. The real cause, he said, was the rights of the states.

Same man. Two different stories.

So here's the question I want to answer today: Why did eleven states leave the Union in 1860 and 1861? And when they did, why did almost everyone think the war would be over by summer?

We'll come back to Stephens. And to a crowd of people who packed a picnic to go watch a battle.

1:01 One Election

It starts with an election. November 1860. Abraham Lincoln wins the presidency.

Lincoln's party, the Republicans, had one big promise: keep slavery out of the western territories. Lincoln said again and again that he had no plan to touch slavery in the states. Just stop it from spreading.

For much of the South, that was enough. Lincoln wasn't even on the ballot in ten Southern states. He won without a single electoral vote from a slave state.

Six weeks later, on December 20th, South Carolina votes to leave the Union. That's **secession**: a state declaring it is no longer part of the United States.

By February 1861, seven states are gone. They form the Confederate States of America, with Jefferson Davis as president.

And here's the strange part. Lincoln isn't president yet. He won't take office until March. So whatever caused secession, it wasn't anything Lincoln had done as president. *He hadn't done anything yet.*

1:55 In Their Own Words (quiet chapter: no jokes, slower voice)

So why did they go? We don't have to guess. Several states wrote out their reasons, in documents called declarations of causes.

Look at Georgia's. It opens by saying that for ten years the state has had "numerous and serious causes of complaint" against the free states, "with reference to the subject of African slavery."

Mississippi's is even more direct: "Our position is thoroughly identified with the institution of slavery."

And South Carolina's complains that Northern states were passing their own laws to avoid returning people who had escaped slavery. In other words, South Carolina was angry that Northern states were using *their own* states' rights.

Then, in March, Stephens gives his speech in Savannah. The new government, he says, rests on the idea that Black people were not equal to white people, and that slavery was their "natural and normal condition." It's known as the **Cornerstone Speech**.

After the war, the story changed. Davis and Stephens both wrote long books saying the South had fought for states' rights and self-government. Over the next decades, that version spread through monuments, schoolbooks and veterans' groups. It's called the **Lost Cause**: the idea that the Confederacy fought a noble fight for states' rights, and that slavery had little to do with it.

So which do you believe? A good rule for history: *evidence from the moment usually beats stories told afterward.* In 1860 and 1861, the people leaving the Union told us why.

3:24 Which Georgians? (quiet chapter: no jokes, slower voice)

One more thing about how they left. In January 1861, Georgia holds a convention to decide. The vote is 208 to 89 for secession.

Now look at who chose those delegates. White men. No women. And no one who was enslaved, which in Georgia was about 44 percent of the people in the state.

So when we say "Georgia decided," it's worth asking: *which Georgians?*

3:50 Fort Sumter

March 4th, 1861. Lincoln takes office. And he has a problem. In Charleston Harbor sits Fort Sumter, a U.S. Army fort, and its soldiers are running out of food.

If he sends warships, he looks like the one who started a war. If he does nothing, he gives up the fort.

So he tells South Carolina's governor he's sending food. Only food. No new troops, no guns, unless the fort is attacked.

Now the choice belongs to the Confederacy. And on April 12th, 1861, Confederate cannons open fire. After about a day and a half of shelling, the fort surrenders. No one is killed in the bombardment.

But the war has started. Lincoln calls for 75,000 volunteers to put down the rebellion. He orders a **blockade**, warships closing off Southern ports. And he does both before Congress meets. He calls it back, but not until July 4th.

That call for troops tips four more states. Virginia, North Carolina, Tennessee and Arkansas leave rather than help fight other Southern states. That makes eleven.

But four slave states stay in the Union: Delaware, Maryland, Kentucky and Missouri. They're called the **border states**. Lincoln badly needs to keep them. Hold onto that.

So who decided on war? The first shots came from the Confederacy. The answer came from the president, who chose to act first and call Congress later.

5:06 Sizing Up the Sides

So it's war. Who should win?

On paper, the North. More than 22 million people, against about 9 million in the South. And more than a third of the South's people were enslaved. The North had about 90 percent of the country's factory output, and about 70 percent of its railroad miles.

So why did the South think it could win? Three reasons.

One: it didn't have to conquer anybody. It only had to survive. The North had to invade and take the whole thing back.

Two: it fought on its own ground, close to home.

Three: leaders. Many of the army's best officers were Southern. Robert E. Lee said he was offered a top command in the Union army. He turned it down to go with Virginia.

And the South had a bet, called **King Cotton**. Britain's mills ran on Southern cotton. Cut it off, the thinking went, and Britain would have to step in. Hold that thought, too.

The Union's plan was slower. General Winfield Scott wanted to squeeze. Blockade the coast. Take the Mississippi River and cut the Confederacy in two. Newspapers called it the **Anaconda Plan**, after the snake that crushes its prey.

People wanted something faster.

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6:24 A Picnic at Bull Run

Summer 1861. Northern newspapers are shouting "Forward to Richmond!" The Confederate capital is only about 100 miles from Washington. One big battle, people think, and it's over.

On July 21st, a Union army meets the Confederates near a creek in Virginia called Bull Run. And they have company. Congressmen, reporters and curious people ride out from Washington in carriages to watch. Some reportedly bring picnic baskets.

Look at this. War, as a day out.

For a while, the Union seems to be winning. Then Confederate reinforcements arrive by train. The Union line breaks. Soldiers run, and they run right into the spectators. Carriages, wagons and soldiers jam the road back to Washington.

Nearly 5,000 men are killed, wounded, captured or missing. Both sides learn the same thing that day. *This is not going to be quick.*

7:11 What They Walked Into (quiet chapter: no jokes, slower voice)

The biggest group of soldiers on both sides were young farmers.

And they carried a new weapon. The old smoothbore musket was accurate to maybe 100 yards. The new **rifled musket** had grooves inside the barrel that spun a soft lead bullet, the **Minié ball**. It could hit a target several times farther away.

But generals still used the old tactics: long lines of men, shoulder to shoulder, marching straight at the enemy. New weapons, old tactics. That's a big part of why the battles became so deadly.

And bullets weren't even the biggest killer. Disease was. Camps were crowded and dirty. Doctors didn't know germs existed.

When a Minié ball shattered an arm or a leg, the most common surgery was **amputation**. It wasn't carelessness. Before antibiotics, it was often the surest way to stop a deadly infection.

By the end, an estimated 750,000 soldiers would die. About two out of every three died of disease, not battle.

Their letters home show why they kept going. Union soldiers wrote about saving the Union, and over time, more of them wrote about ending slavery. Confederate soldiers wrote about defending their homes and their independence, and many wrote about slavery. The Confederates had it harder, too, always short of food, shoes and uniforms.

And prison camps were worse than anything. At Andersonville, in southwest Georgia, about 13,000 Union prisoners died.

8:36 Back to Stephens

So let's go back to the question. Why did eleven states leave?

The people who left told us. Lincoln's election meant slavery would not spread west. Seven states left before he took office. Four more left when he called for troops. And the vice president of the Confederacy called slavery its cornerstone.

And why did everyone think it would be quick? Because each side counted its own strengths. The North counted people and factories. The South counted its generals, its home ground, and King Cotton. Then they met at Bull Run, and the spectators ran for Washington with everybody else.

After the war, Stephens told a different story. But in March 1861, he told us exactly what he thought his new country was for.

The war had started. Nobody knew yet what it would end.

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Thanks for watching. Next time: how a war to save the Union became a war about freedom. Subscribe, and I'll see you then.